



Routledge Handbook of Yoga and Meditation Studies

Edited by Suzanne Newcombe
and Karen O'Brien-Kop

ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOK OF YOGA AND MEDITATION STUDIES

The *Routledge Handbook of Yoga and Meditation Studies* is a comprehensive and interdisciplinary resource, which frames and contextualises the rapidly expanding fields that explore yoga and meditative techniques. The book analyses yoga and meditation studies in a variety of religious, historical and geographical settings. The chapters, authored by an international set of experts, are laid out across five sections:

- Introduction to yoga and meditation studies
- History of yoga and meditation in South Asia
- Doctrinal perspectives: technique and praxis
- Global and regional transmissions
- Disciplinary framings

In addition to up-to-date explorations of the history of yoga and meditation in the Indian subcontinent, new contexts include a case study of yoga and meditation in the contemporary Tibetan diaspora, and unique summaries of historical developments in Japan and Latin America as well as an introduction to the growing academic study of yoga in Korea. Underpinned by critical and theoretical engagement, the volume provides an in-depth guide to the history of yoga and meditation studies and combines the best of established research with attention to emerging directions for future investigation. This handbook will be of interest to multidisciplinary academic audiences from across the humanities, social sciences and sciences.

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A NOTE ON TERMS AND TRANSLATIONS

We have included transliteration of non-English terms in languages such as Sanskrit, Chinese, Tibetan and Japanese. Some authors have chosen to occasionally employ the script of the languages they work in, such as Devanagari for Sanskrit or logograms for Chinese. Some chapters use Hindi, Prakrit, Pali or Bengali rather than Sanskrit terms in transliteration, which creates some variance in spellings: for example, *āsana* in Sanskrit is *āsan* in Hindi. Where a chapter engages substantially with a non-English technical vocabulary, we have included a short glossary of terms at the end of the chapter. We have reserved diacritics (especially in Sanskrit and Hindi) for chapters where the author employs them because they engage directly with primary sources in original languages.

PART I

Introduction to yoga and meditation studies

The overall aim of this section – and the volume as a whole – is to think about what can be gained by reflecting on meditation and yoga *together* as closely related (and overlapping) techniques. Here we highlight some of the main themes and contexts in which the academic study of yoga and meditation currently exists.

In particular, we want to draw attention to the contemporary, global, postcolonial and neo-liberal social contexts and power structures in which we all operate. But, additionally, we want to emphasise the importance of recognising the complex relationships between individual scholars' identities and the construction of academic debates and disciplines.



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REFRAMING YOGA AND MEDITATION STUDIES

Karen O'Brien-Kop and Suzanne Newcombe

Introduction

The study of yoga and meditation is not new. The techniques that we now associate with the terms 'meditation' and 'yoga' are documented over thousands of years in nuanced explorations by practitioners and theorists. However, the 'outsider' study of these practices is intimately connected with the knowledge construction projects of European modernity. As the Peruvian philosopher Anibal Quijano (amongst others) has pointed out, modernity was, for the majority of the world, an experience of coloniality; the conceptual frameworks of European modernity co-arise with the experiences, cultural oppressions and transformations of colonisation (Quijano 2000). In many ways our understandings of practices of meditation and yoga, and their popularised meanings, have been filtered and distorted through the epistemic frameworks that have become dominant and globalised during this period. By examining the study of meditation and yoga through a range of disciplines and in a number of specific cultural and historical contexts, we hope to begin a conversation that challenges assumptions created by cultural positioning, disciplinary training and the blind spots to which they almost inevitably give rise.

This volume is aimed at students and educators and aspires to showcase the range, depth and complexity of current, global academic research on yoga and meditation. As such, this volume mostly takes the stance of the 'outsider' perspective to the study of yoga and meditation, although it does include many insider, theological and blended viewpoints. In the past few decades and in line with the rapid expansion of globalised meditation and yoga, there has been a correlative increase in academic studies of yoga and meditation from a range of perspectives. Recent research has been published not only from within established disciplines such as sociology, anthropology, indology, religious studies and medical-based science, but also from newly emerging and interdisciplinary approaches, such as political theory (Kale and Novetzke forthcoming) or critical and cultural race studies (e.g. Gandhi forthcoming). The increased academic interest reflects that yoga and meditation studies is significantly shifting from a submerged sub-field within selected disciplines to a visible field of study in its own right, one that is both multidisciplinary and interdisciplinary and increasingly transregional.

The chapters in this volume not only consolidate the contemporary field of academic knowledge on yoga and meditation, but also push the boundaries of existing research and explore emerging and future directions of study. By investigating the meanings and assumptions behind practices associated with yoga and meditation in a variety of contexts, in specific historical

periods and through different theological and disciplinary lenses, the authors of this volume contribute to a breaking up of siloed knowledge and rigid conceptual frameworks.

Historically, the field of yoga and meditation studies has not developed evenly. By the end of the twentieth century, academic study of Buddhism and meditation was firmly established in university departments of area studies and in selected humanities disciplines such as religious studies – and was increasingly a subject of biomedical/psycho-physical studies. However, the academic study of yoga traditions has only just emerged as a distinct category of research in the twenty-first century. This handbook is one of the first attempts to bring into direct dialogue two closely related areas of academic research: meditation and yoga. At times this dialogue has been easier to initiate than at other times – since, for some of the scholars whom we invited, the disciplinary areas of expertise, the questions asked and the assumptions made about their objects of study made it hard to see how their particular scholarly agenda would benefit from being part of interdisciplinary reflections.

In an effort to promote interdisciplinary dialogue and awareness between contributors, we organised an authors' workshop in early 2019, held in London, UK, at the School of Oriental and African Studies (SOAS) with support from the Open University.¹ In this forum, scholars exchanged comments on the first-draft papers, with the intention of creating a more coherent volume. This workshop was closely informed and supported by two interdisciplinary European Research Council funded projects on the history of yoga in South Asia, namely AYURYOG and the Haṭha Yoga Project. Both of these projects sought to cultivate interdisciplinary methods to shine new light on their subjects through *longue durée* lenses. For AYURYOG, this was to examine the histories and entanglements of yoga, ayurveda and *rasaśāstra* (alchemy and iatro-chemistry) from the tenth century to the present, focusing on the disciplines' health, rejuvenation and longevity practices. For the Haṭha Yoga Project, the concern was how to identify the origins of both *haṭha* and modern yoga through multidisciplinary approaches of philology, ethnography and cultural history – and at times forging interdisciplinary approaches such as 'embodied philology', the interpretation of historical texts on *āsana* with the aid (and limits) of contemporary practitioner bodies. The diversity of the discussion over the course of these two days was inspiring. We hope that the new perspectives generated will have ripple effects on the framing of many of the participants' research beyond the scope of this particular volume.

Both of the editors of this volume work primarily in the field of yoga studies and, although we have aimed to include a broad range of approaches from the field of meditation and contemplative studies, we acknowledge that the content is slightly more weighted towards the topic of yoga. While some chapters are interdisciplinary (see, for instance, Li, Chapter 26, which integrates philology and digital humanities), other chapters are multidisciplinary (Bühnemann, Chapter 29, combines art history, material culture and religious studies) or cross-disciplinary (Gerety, Chapter 34, in part, employs sound studies to elucidate history of religions).² However, in the last section of the book, which focuses on 'disciplinary framings' we also see that the understanding of what yoga or meditation *is* and *does* can shift depending on the questions asked and methods of research. For example, a focus on measurable characteristics in psychophysiology yields a different understanding of yoga and meditation than exploring the social context of yoga with the tools of critical theory. The scope of this volume's essays from scholars around the world ensures that a considerable range of perspectives has been included from across the combined field of yoga and meditation studies and that there is ample opportunity for readers to think and analyse laterally across these complex and intertwined topics, regions, approaches and chronologies.

As editors, we also acknowledge that we are situated in the humanities and social sciences, primarily as scholars of religion. The hard sciences are not represented to the extent that we

would have liked, but we have two excellent dedicated science-based chapters, one on biomedicine (Chapter 30) and one on cognitive psychology (Chapter 31), as well as a range of scientific perspectives incorporated in other chapters. It is worth reflecting on the institutionalised structures of knowledge, reward and research finance in this area: many of the scientists that we reached out to were unwilling to commit to publishing in a cross-disciplinary forum and to a publishing format – an edited collection – which is singular to the humanities and social sciences. In the hard sciences, the outputs for hard-won research hours are standard science journal articles (usually by large teams of co-researchers). Often research into health interventions (which is a common focus for yoga and meditation studies in these disciplines) also need to demonstrate the potential to generate or at least to save money in the context of the healthcare market. The academic environment is therefore increasingly driven by constrained research outputs and specific research funding opportunities. An important challenge for social science and humanities researchers going forward is to impress upon both biomedical researchers and the general public the importance of understanding health interventions *in context* – that their healing and meaning-giving potential cannot be reduced to, or fully understood by, biomedical measurements. Conversely, it can also be helpful for humanities and ‘soft’ science scholars to have a better understanding of how the body is likely to react to certain psycho-physical techniques and what this might mean for the social construction of traditions and ontological understandings of reality.

Defining meditation and yoga: the challenges

Across this collection, scholars have grappled with central questions, themes and tensions inherent in studying these subjects in the contemporary world and from within the often Euro- and America-centric academic traditions. First and foremost among our projects has been the exploration and problematising of the very definitions of terms such as ‘yoga’, ‘meditation’, ‘contemplation’, and spiritual ‘discipline’ across chronology, region and religious categories. We have long since moved beyond the twentieth-century view of yoga and meditation as ‘timeless’ or ‘universal’ traditions of the ‘Mystic East’ (see King 1999). Rather, when we probe more deeply, we discover the many nuances of these somewhat general terms and that there are multiple definitions and accounts of yoga and meditation that are particular to specific contexts.

When a scholar sets out to formally define ‘yoga’ and/or ‘meditation’ there are many challenges to confront, not least at the basic level of language. For example, scholars encounter translation difficulties, such as which words may reasonably be translated as ‘meditation’ from different languages. While *dhyāna* in Sanskrit, *jìngzuò* (静坐) in Japanese, and *shouyi* (守一) in Chinese Daoist discourse are often translated into English with the word ‘meditation’, more technically they denote ‘absorption’ (*dhyāna*), ‘quiet sitting’ (*jìngzuò*), and ‘guarding the one’ (*shouyi*). It is equally possible to assert that these varied practices are entirely disparate and disconnected and should not be grouped under the umbrella term of ‘meditation.’ The scholar faces similarly challenging philological choices: e.g. did *yogācāra* mean ‘discipline of yoga’ for classical South Asian Buddhists or something generic such as ‘spiritual conduct’? What happens to an experiential categorisation of *samādhi* as a singular type of ‘meditative concentration’ when some Mahāyāna Buddhist texts note that types of *samādhis* run, numerically, into the millions? (See Deleanu, Chapter 7.) Furthermore, one has to negotiate semantic change and slippage across time and language: be it within a Sanskrit text or as a borrowed word, what does *yoga* denote in different cultures, languages and eras? Finally, contemporary definitions often eclipse historical definitions and can lead to anachronistic, misinformed or simply skewed understandings of the past discussions of yoga as recorded in textual sources. On the other hand,

contemporary definitions of yoga and identities within particular meditative traditions can be weighed down by the ideological anchor of historical 'authenticity' with no room for organic change and development in meaning or understanding.

Then there are the challenges of defining a *practice* of 'yoga' or 'meditation'. Is yoga a means to an end (a set of techniques) or the goal itself (the end state of liberation)? Where does ritual end and meditation begin? (Is lighting a candle a ritual act or a meditative act, or both?) How do we, as scholars, reconstruct past or present practices of yoga and meditation, taking into account the dilemmas of the etic/emic perspectives and the often thorny topic of insider and outsider identities and statuses? Furthermore, what are our presumptions about practice in relation to yoga and meditation? If yoga is understood as primarily characterised by 'visible' practices such as posture and breathing technique, then is meditation understood as an inner or 'invisible' set of techniques? Do the categories of 'meditation' and 'yoga' reproduce a Cartesian dualism of 'mind' and 'body' that is reductive and Eurocentric? Again, our survey of traditions and regions in this volume demonstrates that meditation practice may be just as bodily and demonstrative as any conception of yoga – e.g. Jain walking meditation with fixed gaze (see Pragya, Chapter 13). Indeed, the characterisation of meditation as an 'inner' and silent experience is, in part, a product of the European colonial privileging of Theravāda Buddhist meditation as *the* meditation technique *par excellence* (see Husgafvel, Chapter 3).

A further challenge awaits the scholar in dealing with the field of yoga or meditation studies itself. Since the term 'yoga' has been specifically limited in its application to South Asia and its derived contexts and transmissions, the field of yoga studies is, in many ways, more clearly demarcated. The term 'meditation', however, has a semantic provenance and currency far beyond South Asia, is more culturally neutral, and has been used to define spiritual practices in a range of religions, regions and time periods. As a consequence, the academic field of meditation studies is more difficult to delimit than yoga studies, because it is more disparate culturally. In the case of meditation, all roads do not lead back to South Asia, as they do for yoga. Distinct traditions of contemplation can be traced to ancient Greek concepts of self-care and meditation/contemplation, to the Chinese practices glossed as 'sitting', or to a range of other cultural contexts.

In this volume, we have dealt with a further valence in the definition of yoga in particular. One of the questions that arose was the way in which authors working on different time periods were using the same technical terms. For example, take the case of *haṭhayoga*. This term conveys a different meaning from its early Buddhist mention in South Asian *yogācāra* literature in the c. third century CE (as a 'forceful process' although its method is not explained) (Mallinson 2020: 5), to a medieval context in the fifteenth-century *Haṭhapradīpikā* (indicating the yoga of force, but now encompassing a specific set of techniques), to its popular twenty-first-century anglophone branding as 'gentle stretching in a traditional Indian style'.³ As editors, we therefore discussed how to differentiate the premodern from the modern referents using a stylistic device.⁴ In order to distinguish a modern *haṭhayoga* (indicating post-Vivekānanda, anglophone, asana-focused yoga) from its historical precedents, we opted for the anglicised Hatha Yoga (or more generically hatha yoga). Hatha Yoga is how the term is primarily written in early twentieth-century primary sources in English. In contrast to this borrowed 'Hatha Yoga' in English, we reserve italics and diacritics for the Sanskrit *haṭhayoga* as discussed in premodern South Asian sources, but also for contemporary traditional practices in India that use the term *haṭha*. This indicates a theoretical stance on the need to engage in a constant critical reflection on the meaning of the terms that we employ as scholars, rather than sliding into a comfort zone about what 'yoga' means. This editorial choice also asks the reader to maintain a critical enquiry into the questions of continuity and rupture in traditions of yoga, and it strongly challenges perennialist assumptions of a single yoga that is true for all times, places and people.

We wish to avoid, however, an elision of the entanglements between historical and modern practices of meditation and yoga with this stylistic distinction; it is certainly the case that many ‘traditional’ forms of yoga and meditation (i.e. historically continuous practices) continue to exist today. Indeed further discussion and deconstruction of the term *haṭha* shows it as unstable and polyvalent even before the *Haṭhapradīpikā* (see Singleton, Chapter 9). Finally, the stylistic intervention that we have applied in this volume to *haṭhayoga* and Hatha Yoga can equally be applied to other relevant terms that have potent cross-linguistic currency and a ‘brand value’ outside of their original historical contexts, such as *vipassanā* and Vipassana, *aṣṭāṅga yoga* and Ashtanga Yoga, or *āsana* and asana. This nuanced approach points to the unique historical context of South Asian yoga and meditation, and it also highlights singular developments and innovations in transnational yoga and meditation.

Contributors to this volume have also sought to clarify the extent to which concepts and practices of ‘meditation’ and ‘yoga’ can be regarded as distinct or overlapping in a particular tradition, context or time period. In some traditions, yoga and meditation have been used synonymously, while in others they are separate. For example, in early South Asia, Patañjali defines yoga as concentration (*samādhi*) (*Pātañjalayogaśāstra* 1.1),⁵ indicating that the primary understanding of yoga in this period was as meditative practice. In a contemporary context, Ville Husgafvel (Chapter 3) discusses the relationship between meditation and yoga from a meditation studies point of view, pointing to the many entanglements, such as the inclusion of yoga postures in various Mindfulness-Based Practices (MBPs). In other contexts, however, we see that a stricter demarcation has been maintained between the two disciplines. In Japan, the longstanding historical importance of meditation traditions – inclusive of Daoism, Confucianism, Buddhism, Shinto and more modern interpretations – far outweighs the cultural contact with postural-based yoga in the later twentieth century. Furthermore, in many contexts, practices of yoga and meditation intersect with a broader category of ‘asceticism’, from which it can be difficult to differentiate discrete concepts of yoga and/or meditation.

Another key question has been the ways in which specific practices of ‘yoga’ or ‘meditation’ can lead to unique experiences, effects and understandings. For example, a particular practice of ‘meditation’ or ‘yoga’ in one context can look very different to other practices that carry the same label – e.g. *kuṇḍalinī yoga* in medieval Kashmir as explored by Olga Serbaeva Saraogi in Chapter 8, or in contemporary Assam and present-day USA as explored by Sravana Borkataky-Varma in Chapter 25. Equally, we encounter practices, habits and codes in historical traditions that may not be explicitly called yoga or meditation but which appear to entail similar traits and outcomes – e.g. the practices of early Buddhism in South Asia (Deleanu, Chapter 7) or the Sufi breathing techniques of medieval South Asia (D’Silva, Chapter 15). In grouping together various endeavours under an umbrella term such as ‘meditation’ for the purposes of scholarly analysis, one has to ask whether, in today’s world and at the level of experience, there are *any* connections between the contemporary mindfulness of Kabat-Zinn and mantra recitation (*mantra-jap*) in Sikhism, or between yogic jumping techniques (Beps) in Tibetan Buddhism and ‘Christian yoga’ in the USA, or between Daoist *qi* and yogic *prāṇa*. The artificiality of the analytical categories of ‘yoga’ and ‘meditation’ can unintentionally revive and reify the perennialist view all over again. However, this is emphatically not the intention of this volume. Rather than proposing an answer to the above question, the juxtaposition of perspectives here hopes to create more, better and new questions – and to begin to reframe the discussion.

Finally, there is the issue of what is to be regarded as ‘yoga’ and/or ‘meditation’: if a practitioner or community defines a particular practice or phenomenon as ‘yoga’ or ‘meditation’, even though it appears to be at radical odds with established and traditional forms – witness recent social media discussions about ‘goat yoga’ or ‘beer yoga’, for example – should it

be dismissed evaluatively as 'non-authentic'? This is a discussion that Andrea Jain takes up in Chapter 5. On the whole, this research handbook seeks to shift the contemporary framing of yoga beyond the limited binary debates of 'tradition' and 'authenticity' versus 'non-tradition' and 'non-authenticity.' Yes, tracing how orthogenetic developments have occurred within and without South Asia is still important (and well covered in section two of this volume), but there are also broader global questions to be asked: In what ways and contexts might yoga and meditation practices cause harm? Is there any yoga on the planet that is not today embroiled in neoliberal capitalism? In what ways are yoga and meditation being weaponised at an international scale as tools of political, religious, racial, economic and cultural hegemony?

Shifting discussions and emerging areas of research

As editors we are committed to the project of 'decolonising yoga' and have endeavoured to encompass a diversity of views that have the potential to decentre traditional or dominant narratives, be they epistemic, cultural or regional. For example, this volume includes chapters that, for the first time in English, explore developments of yoga and meditation traditions in Korea and in Latin America (see Park and Park, Chapter 22; Muñoz, Chapter 23) – as well as a chapter that introduces new research from Japan (see Kurita, Chapter 21). Additionally, through this collection of studies we are attempting to bring areas of established (but previously niche) research to wider audiences of yoga and meditation studies, such as the significance of yoga and meditation traditions in Insular Southeast Asia (see Aciri, Chapter 19). We were able to include theological perspectives in the chapters on yoga and meditation in Jain and Sikh traditions (see Pragya, Chapter 13; Bhogal, Chapter 16). And we have asked all of our contributors to consider insider and outsider implications in their own research, including the complex category of the scholar-practitioner. Furthermore, we also explored how different agendas, questions and interest groups drive current research in our various disciplinary areas of study – a topic thoroughly discussed at the authors' workshop in March 2019. We have therefore aimed to engage in reflexive scholarship on the academic approaches and identities that inform the field. However, shifting the understandings created and maintained by academic power structures and methods of studying is a slow process, and proposing viable alternatives is not necessarily easy or straightforward.

The first step toward creating new assumptions for discussion is to draw attention to what is missing and to those perspectives that have yet to be represented at the table. We regret the limited extent to which we were able to include scholars of yoga and meditation trained at and holding positions at educational institutions in South Asia. Additionally, we were not able to include a chapter that could explore the recent exponential growth of yoga in China or a detailed analysis of the exchange of yogic and meditative practices between China and its neighbours in Asia from the Chinese perspective. Understandings about yoga and meditation in Eastern European and former communist cultures is also a topic that needs more sustained attention in global studies of these techniques and practices. Furthermore, the regional histories and contemporary contexts of yoga and meditation in Africa and the Middle East are vital areas for future, sustained research. Unfortunately, one volume cannot cover everything – but it can highlight and spearhead some important emerging areas for required focus.

One significant area of emerging research is the acknowledgement and analysis of how abuses of power and sexuality have been embedded in many contemporary (and historical) yoga and meditation movements. There are wide-ranging studies of abusive behaviour in many of the groups associated with practices that gained popularity after World War II. Such studies have been undertaken in the context of sociology of religion – particularly in research

on ‘new religious movements’ (NRMs) – and in psychological studies on ‘cultic abuse’ and (more recently) ‘coercive control.’⁶ But until the last decade, there was little public discussion of institutionalised abuse, particularly institutionalised sexual abuse. This culture change is facilitating a new framing of research into this important area. Central to future enquiry will be theorisations of race, gender, culture and power and the ways in which intersections of these factors have produced, facilitated and covered up abusive behaviour. This handbook is being produced at the start of a five-year Luce Foundation funded project into ‘Sexual Abuse and Religious Movements’ which is headed by Amanda Lucia at the University of California–Riverside – and its emerging research agenda promises to include in its publications and output a broad range of groups that have yoga and meditation as central practices. Although several of the contributions in this volume mention the issue of abuse in groups and movements (e.g. Jain, Chapter 5; Wong, Chapter 32), we regret that we were not able to include a substantive chapter on this issue as a stand-alone subject.

Early pioneering work on structural inequalities within both academic and practitioner communities interested in yoga and meditation has been undertaken by scholars working on the intersections of gender and capitalism and research groups such as Race and Yoga⁷ (see for example: Jain 2015, 2020; Black 2016; Lucia 2018; Godrej 2017; Gandhi forthcoming). In recent years, there have been key reflections on race, whiteness and Buddhism in the west (e.g. Yancy and McRae 2019; Gleig 2019). Yet critical race theory is still to be integrated and applied within mainstream research in yoga studies. The bulk of the work on race and yoga to date has been produced by women of colour working in the USA, and the burden of drawing attention to social and structural inequities has not yet been shouldered (or discussed reflexively) by significant numbers of white scholars. In line with developments in critical race theory and decolonial approaches, analysis of race in yoga and meditation communities will focus more on whiteness and its cultural manifestations globally. There may also be further scrutiny to ensure that broader demographic and institutional power structures are not automatically replicated in communities of academic scholar-practitioners. A pernicious consequence of colonialism, cultural appropriation and religious exoticism is evident in the fact that while aspects of South Asian culture are pick’n’mixed – from the fashion industry to commercialised yoga – citizens of South Asian heritage are still stereotyped and vilified as terrorists in the global north (see e.g. Bald 2015). Even as yoga reaches the farthest corners of small-town US culture, there are still fundamental misunderstandings of South Asian religion and culture so that Sikhs, for example, are attacked as ‘Muslim terrorists’ because of their turbans.⁸ In many cases, a romanticised and highly selective skimming-off of South Asian cultures has been carried out by white yoga practitioners, to the detriment of engaging with these cultures as integral, living traditions.

Further disciplinary developments in yoga studies will take place in South Asian textual studies related to yoga and meditation, where there has been a firm emphasis on translating Sanskrit texts for the past 200 years. However, there is growing recognition of the many texts yet to be translated and studied in other languages such as Hindi, Urdu and Bengali, and even more so the languages of southern India, such as Tamil, Malayālam and Telugu. Texts and archives in these languages, both premodern and modern, will offer up new information on the history and development of yoga and meditation in South Asia – and steer attention beyond the *Yogasūtra* and *Bhagavadgītā* towards non-elite sources such as songs, poems, tracts, manuals, letters, and popular and literary works. Considerable ground has been gained in acknowledging the diversity of South Asian religious traditions in the development of yoga – including Buddhism, Jainism and Islam – but further work remains to be done in order to develop this body of knowledge. Ongoing rapid developments in digital humanities will continue to alleviate the

painstaking burden of creating critical editions of original texts and analysing large corpuses, and such innovations will lead to new insights into old texts at a faster rate.

There is an increasing number of projects that are in various ways connected to the aims of social justice, be it the debates around 'engaged' or 'disengaged' Buddhism or those around 'on the mat/off the mat' activism in yoga. Also growing in number are projects seeking to instigate social change for underprivileged groups – from yoga and mindfulness in prisons, to yoga and meditation for refugees. These developments in political and social activism will also be instantiated in already complex scholar-practitioner identities, leading to new forms of embodied academic critiques, political dissent and socially-engaged knowledge modalities. Finally, an emergent area of interest, on which there is yet to be substantial published research, is the relationship between yoga and technology. The impacts of robot yoga teachers, robot monks chanting in Buddhist temples, digital gurus, meditation headsets and consciousness implants are among the many topics currently under investigation (see Singleton forthcoming).

Concluding remarks

Interdisciplinary research is vital to the development of yoga and meditation studies. This kind of knowledge exchange is essential to strengthen the field and to make sense of complex and fast-moving global developments. How can lab-based scientists measure the benefits (and potential detriments) of a meditation technique if they do not understand the social contexts in which these practices were developed historically and are presently taught? How can one decode the meaning of historical texts on *haṭhayoga* postures without the referent of embodied interpretation?

We hope that the sheer range of contributions in this volume will help to continue the widening of both academic and practitioner assumptions about the diversity and complexity of traditions of yoga and meditation. Moreover, it is our aim that this collaborative reframing will eventually transform lived understandings beyond the scholars and practitioners who are specifically interested in the techniques of yoga and meditation. The intention of this volume is to generate more nuanced insights into the depth of global traditions of meditation and yoga in order to contribute to a wider reframing of shared understandings of the categories of religion, science, spirituality, politics and culture.

Notes

- 1 The workshop 'Disciplines and Dialogue: The Future of Yoga and Meditation Studies' was attended by more than forty international scholars who shared their research; this two-day workshop was generously funded by the Strategic Research Investment Fund at the Open University's Faculty of Arts and Social Science and supported in kind by the Centre of Yoga Studies at SOAS University of London.
- 2 Interdisciplinarity involves integrating or synthesizing two or more disciplines in a single study to create a new approach; cross-disciplinarity entails using one discipline to examine another; multi-disciplinarity employs a range of disciplinary approaches in one study without attempting to synthesize them. For further discussion, especially on interdisciplinarity, see Graff 2015: 1–19.
- 3 As one yoga website states: 'Today, the term hatha is used in such a broad way that it is difficult to know what a particular hatha class will be like. In most cases, however, it will be relatively gentle, slow and great for beginners or students who prefer a more relaxed style where they hold poses longer.' www.doyogawithme.com/types-of-yoga. Accessed 11 March 2020.
- 4 On this subject, we wish to express our gratitude to Mark Singleton for his valuable insights and dialogue with us on the subject.

- 5 The commentary (*bhāṣya*) to *sūtra* 1.1 states, *yogaḥ samādhiḥ*, ‘yoga is concentration’. It also states, *sa samprajñāto yoga ity ākhyāyate*, ‘That cognitive form [of concentration; of *samādhi*] is called yoga.’ (Maas 2006: 2–3; trans O’Brien-Kop).
- 6 The following references may help to further explore this topic: Caldwell 2001; Crovetto 2008 and 2011; Barker 1987 and 2009; Downing 2001; Jacobs 2007; Lewis 2011; Palmer 2018 and 1994; Palmer and Hardman 1999; Rochford 1998, 2007 and 2011; Masis 2007; Urban 2003 and 2011; van Eck Duymaer van Twist 2014 and 2015; Voix 2008.
- 7 https://escholarship.org/uc/crg_raceandyoga. Accessed 24 July 2020.
- 8 See, for example, this news story: <https://edition.cnn.com/2016/09/15/us/sikh-hate-crime-victims/index.html>. Accessed 11 March 2020.

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2

DECOLONISING YOGA

Shameem Black

Why decolonise?

Does modern yoga need decolonising? And can modern yoga assist with larger projects of decolonisation? The answer to both questions – simultaneously – may be yes. Grappling with yoga through the lens of postcolonial critique can expose the ways in which yogic practice can develop in complicity with imperial configurations, while it can also shed light on how the practice might support emancipatory social projects. Ironically, it is sometimes the very desire to decolonise the practice that can reinscribe yoga within alternative forms of hierarchy. No practice is solely emancipatory, yet no practice is bereft of the potential to liberate. These ambivalences continue to shape yoga today.

This essay addresses three concerns that have acquired increasing salience in the twenty-first century. First, to what extent is the construction of modern yoga a colonial production of orientalist discursive domination? Second, to what extent does the modern practice of yoga beyond South Asian borders constitute a practice of cultural appropriation? Finally, how might the resurgent nationalist Indian interest in yoga decolonise the practice? I address the first question in the section ‘Knowledge, body, empire’; the second in ‘Travel, positionality, power’; and the third in ‘Nationalism, decolonisation, recolonisation’. I end with an invitation for yoga studies scholarship to continue its experiments with decolonising cultural critique in an era of neoliberal globalisation.

In this chapter, yoga signifies a diverse constellation of practices that people call or have called yoga in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, rather than practices that conform to a foundational philosophical definition. I focus primarily on legacies of British colonialism and India’s engagement with western Anglophone countries, where these questions have grown particularly urgent. ‘Decolonial’, as used in this chapter, refers to the active practice of contesting specific hierarchical configurations of power. A more transformative approach to decolonising yoga would investigate complex histories of yoga, hierarchy and emancipation in other parts of the world, taking us beyond the Eurocentric boundaries reaffirmed by the concept of ‘post-colonial’. The need for such scholarship constitutes a key future direction for yoga studies.

While particular presentations of yoga sometimes cultivate an image of being outside regimes of power, the practice has long played diverse political roles. In the twenty-first century, the practice has gained new political vitality. Precisely because yoga has taken on a role as a person-making project and a mode of state theatrics, it becomes important to ask what yoga’s rising popularity means for a current understanding of imperial and neo-imperial power relations. By acknowledging more fully how yogic practices have emerged in dialogue with hierarchical

formations, we can best cultivate yoga as a practice that challenges, as well as instrumentalises, the neo-imperial projects of our day.

Knowledge, body, empire

The twenty-first-century scholarly mapping of yoga's modern history from the sixteenth century to the present has revealed that yogic practice communities have long been political. David Gordon White's extensive work in South Asian folkloric traditions exposes the yogi not as a peace-loving practitioner of *āsana*, but instead as a sinister soul-stealer who works close to kingly might (White 2009). Mughal emperors, aiming to bolster support among their Hindu subjects, demonstrated keen interest in yoga and commissioned visual representations of yogic communities (Parikh 2015: 227). Paintings from this era suggest how closely those communities were watched as a potential resource for – and possible threat to – imperial control. Yogic mercenaries, as William Pinch shows, became power brokers in a seventeenth- and eighteenth-century India shaped by British imperial incursions. These groups of organised armed ascetics, knowledgeable in a wide range of military technologies, 'would apply these skills *against* the British in late eighteenth-century Bengal ... and *for* the British in Bundelkhand after 1800' (Pinch 2006: 255). This uncertainty around yogic political allegiance leads us to question how yoga has historically been co-created within diverse imperial frames: if not exactly a product of empire, then certainly a product *within* and *through* empire.

Common conceptions of yoga are indebted to modes of knowledge production and social ideologies that emerged in dialogue with nineteenth- and twentieth-century colonial norms. Archival scholarship shows how yogis were often recorded in British and European accounts as exotic contortionists who sat outside western conceptions of respectable life (Singleton 2010). This understanding was shared by Indian intellectuals, such as Swami Vivekānanda, who rehabilitated yoga to align with neo-Hindu reform movements and to appeal to a bourgeois western audience. Many key Indian spiritual leaders who popularised such texts as the *Yogasūtra* were influenced by western groups who produced particular ideas of Indian religiosity for their own purposes (White 2014). Histories of breath control in this period reveal how yoga could be constructed both in opposition to and in concert with British ideals of physical cultivation (Green 2008). Yoga thus emerges as the paradoxical product of colonial modernity, transcultural engagement and broader global exercises of western power.

This rehabilitation process made yoga available as an anti-colonial resource to produce indigenous masculinity. The anti-colonial nationalist Aurobindo Ghose, for instance, reimagined the colonial jail cell as a 'revolutionary ashram' (Wolfers 2016: 525). Others, like the Maharaja of the Mysore Palace, saw in yoga the potential for a physical vocabulary that would strengthen the nation's young men. This project appealed to the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), where yogic postural practice became aligned – sometimes ambivalently and paradoxically – with the project of making pure, militant and specifically Hindu Indian male bodies (Alter 2004).¹ Hindu nationalists such as V. D. Savarkar drew on articulations of *karma-yoga* in the *Bhagavad Gītā* to develop a Hindu call to arms (Chaturvedi 2010). Framing the practice in opposing terms, Gandhi situated yoga between nonviolent anti-colonial resistance and biomoral public health reform (Alter 2000). These political projects, in all their diversity, used yoga to reimagine anti-colonial masculinities.

Yoga was also to a varying extent supported by western authorities in India. The YMCA was a famous promoter of postural practice, indicating that yoga could be remodulated to serve muscular Christianity and its investment in the ideals of the British empire (Singleton 2010). The yogic body was reshaped in the colonial period in ways that conformed to western ideals

of pleasing bodies, featuring sculpted musculature rather than ash-rubbed skin. The practice was sometimes taken up by the British themselves as a supposedly Aryan mode of regenerating imperial masculinity at a time of crisis for the empire (Imy 2016).

More generally, many ideas of yoga in late-nineteenth and twentieth-century Anglophone circuits reaffirmed the orientalist construction of India as a land of exotic religiosity. When defined as India's core strength – a project endorsed by numerous Indian intellectuals, such as Paramahansa Yogananda (Yogananda 1946) – this emphasis on spiritual seeking could be used to justify India's inability to self-govern. This construction of yoga further positioned India as a place ready and willing to save alienated westerners from the failures of industrial capitalist modernity. Western cross-cultural practices of yoga, thus, have emerged within a larger field of knowledge about an imagined 'India' that resonates with Edward Said's emphasis on exotic alterity and political weakness in relation to the West (Said 1979).

While the development of yoga in the late-nineteenth and twentieth centuries cannot be said to be a purely colonial invention or a naked tool of empire, neither can it be understood as a phenomenon divorced from imperial configurations of knowledge and power. The empire perpetuated fantasies of India as an inexpensive source of spiritual raw material for western projects of personal self-development. At the same time, the empire allowed yoga to become useful as an anti-colonial project. This paradoxical genealogy forms one condition of possibility for the practice today.

Travel, positionality and power

In 1991, India published a series of postage stamps with pictures of *āsana*. This series serves as a fitting emblem to reflect on the twentieth century, an era in which new portraits of yoga began to circulate around the globe with increasing speed. In this century, yoga experienced a mobility sometimes greater than that available to Indians. If the British empire enabled trans-national movement for Indians in the nineteenth century, facilitating large migrations to the Caribbean, Southeast Asia, the Pacific and Africa, the twentieth century also witnessed key contractions. Mid-century racially-exclusive immigration policies in places like Australia (the White Australia policy) and the United States (The Immigration Act of 1924) made it challenging for Indians to take up residence in such countries. After World War II, Britain took in large numbers of Indians, but it sharply limited this migration in the 1960s.² The Indian state also exercised its own forms of control, since Indians were not guaranteed the right to a passport until the Passport Act of 1967.

This context, in which practices and ideas could travel in ways that sometimes people could not, helped to reshape the politics of yoga by transferring key reproductions of the practice away from Indian communities towards communities associated with privilege and mobility in other countries. To be sure, exceptional figures from India could travel to parts of the West to teach yoga, and they were often highly influential. But the broader restrictions on Indian migration meant that in some parts of the world, relatively few people of Indian descent could shape the practice as it was reconfigured in the West. As Americans and Europeans began to travel in greater numbers to India, their mobility has been seen as crucial to the western popularising of yoga (Goldberg 2015 and 2010). This transformation drew strength from increasingly powerful neoliberal logics that encouraged access to spiritual practices through an open marketplace (York 2001). Under these circumstances, Indian culture could become fetishised in a global market, while privileged communities could freely engage with cultural practices – even and often in respectful ways – without substantial attention to the hierarchies potentially constraining Indian people.

At the turn of the twenty-first century, yoga moved to the mainstream of many parts of the world (especially the West). It did so, as Andrea Jain has argued, by effectively linking religious transformation, personal self-development and ideal body cultivation to capitalist modes of reproduction and emerging norms of personal wellbeing (Jain 2015). As yoga became more popular, many western countries – such as the US, the UK, Australia, France and Germany – began to encourage migration from India. Both of these phenomena emerged within a context of ‘expanding Orientalisms’ that shaped public culture for migrants and ethnic minorities in the new millennium (Ramaprasad 2018). These patterns have given rise to contemporary concerns in South Asian studies, critical race theory and ethnic studies. First, how do we understand yoga as a South Asian cosmopolitan practice in countries where people of South Asian descent are ethnic minorities? Second, how does the practice of yoga in multicultural societies work to confirm or complicate pre-existing racial, ethnic or gender hierarchies?

A key rhetoric that has risen in urgency in the twenty-first century is whether yoga practised by people who are not of South Asian descent constitutes cultural appropriation. Some of these questions have emerged in popular culture as forms of cultural policing, especially in light of broader demands from conservative Hindu groups for recognition in a transnational public sphere (Ramachandran 2014). These initiatives have tended to focus on socialising new participants into norms of acceptability (how to practise yoga respectfully, for instance) and on consolidating community borders around normative ideals (such as what it means to be a proper Hindu).

Here I focus on a different approach to the question of cultural appropriation within leftist activism that takes decolonising yoga as a political ideal. In these discourses, cultural appropriation is most usefully understood as a term animated for critical purposes when there appears to be a strong inequality between the valuation of cultural practice and the valuation of people associated with that practice. Such an uneven valuation between Indian culture and South Asian people shapes yoga in many parts of the West. Yoga has enjoyed high popularity in the United States, for instance, in a post-9/11 era when many people of South Asian descent face heightened levels of xenophobia, hate crime, state surveillance and detention (Maira 2009). Seen in this context, some members of the Indian diaspora have begun to question why yoga appears more welcome than they are. Critiques of this nature seek to provoke reflection on this broader context, so that individuals may apprehend how their own practices may bolster troubling social patterns that they do not personally endorse. Seen in this light, the question of ‘cultural appropriation’ is not a call for essentialism or exclusion, but instead an attempt to analyse the place of yoga within larger structures of material privilege, state power and dominant norms.

Theorists of Indo-Chic have argued that the problem posed by cross-cultural practice is that signs of difference, which are often costly for ethnic minorities, are extracted and commodified into signs of cool, which create value for majoritarian subjects. As Anita Mannur and Pia Sahni contend, ‘Indianness becomes the simulacrum through which a mainstream American can establish individuality while allowing an embrace of difference on one’s own terms’ (Mannur and Sahni 2011: 183). Related patterns can also be found in multi-ethnic Europe (Altglas 2014). Yoga analysed in light of Indian global labour markets suggests that political benefits of the practice, once enjoyed mostly by Indian masters, can be widely dispersed to a wide range of cultural positions, yet negative signs remain firmly tethered to Indian subjects (Black 2016). Shreena Gandhi and Lillie Wolff argue that yoga has become desirable because it promises to fix the meaninglessness that emerges when the nourishment of ethnic cultural traditions is traded away for the material benefits of whiteness (Gandhi and Wolff 2017). Seen in this light, yoga may ironically alleviate anxiety for those who benefited the most from settler colonial and imperial enterprises, perfecting the colonial project. Its embrace as a marker of cosmopolitan openness

can support neoliberal modes of self-making without cognisance of the politics of race, ethnicity, gender and class (Luhr 2015; Markula 2015). Without stronger critical attention to this condition of possibility, yoga carries the capacity to mask a larger accounting with history.

Diverse new voices in art and activism have emerged to challenge these cultural logics. Chiraag Bhakta, an Indian American visual artist who goes by the working name of *Pardon My Hindi, created a powerful installation, *#WhitePeopleDoingYoga*, to critique the commodification of yoga in the West. His artist's statement declares:

Brands like Lulu Lemon and Nike have started appropriating and trade-marking phrases, moves and clothing – aligning and embedding themselves in our understanding of yoga, while the South Asian face and voice is relegated to an exotic caricature – cartoons, adoption of South Asian names by white westerners, mystical creatures, Hindu gods.

(*Pardon My Hindi, n.d.)

The uneven flow of benefits described in the statement creates a larger context within which the practice of yoga can seem to need decolonising. New initiatives have emerged to argue for South Asian stewardship over yoga in the West to promote positive forms of South Asian visibility (SAAPYA, n.d.). These groups have themselves been critiqued for enacting diasporic dominance and for ignoring yoga's reinforcement of caste and class hierarchies within South Asia (Patankar 2014). These debates suggest how the goals of ethnic and postcolonial activism may be in tension over what decolonising needs to occur.

Ethnic studies has also initiated key conversations around decolonising yoga to explore how yoga makes meaning for other minorities and indigenous peoples. In these analyses, which often join forces with gendered critiques of exclusionary norms (Berila et al. 2016; Horton and Harvey 2012; Klein and Guest-Jelley 2014), one major source of focus is yoga's accessibility. If South Asian studies has critiqued how yoga may be too readily accessible for subjects in positions of privilege, scholars in ethnic studies point out that the benefits of the practice have not been accessible enough for those whose bodies do not fit social norms around a twenty-first-century ideal yoga body. Many ethnic minorities feel isolated, criminalised or fetishized in yoga, and must work to claim space and legitimacy (Manigault-Bryant 2016; Panton and Evans 2017). These emotions speak to racial economies of feeling that enmesh contemporary yoga within broader legacies of slavery, discrimination and the destruction of indigenous communities (Blu Wakpa 2018). Decolonising yoga in this light requires practice communities to confront legacies that go well beyond India's specific histories of colonialism.

As ethnic and feminist studies critique the dystopian use of racial hierarchies, critical race studies has also advocated embedding yoga more deeply within a broader range of social and cultural norms. New initiatives, such as recalibrating yoga as part of the Black Lives Matter movement (Wortham 2016) or mestiza consciousness (Bost 2016), indicate how the practice can be used to confront traumatic hierarchies that govern everyday life for many people. In this respect, decolonising yoga can indicate an alliance project anchored in the specific political concerns and felt needs of minority communities.

Nationalism, decolonisation, recolonisation

In the twenty-first century, the Indian state has lavished attention on yoga as a vehicle for its soft power aspirations. While this attention may in some respects constitute a project of decolonisation, it also often resembles a process of recolonisation in which nationalist political projects serve very selective parts of India.

Decolonisation, from the perspective of the Indian state, has most powerfully looked like a material project of aiming to protect the economic benefits of yoga for governmental control. India has designated yoga within the category of traditional knowledge subject to protection under the World Trade Organisation by creating a Traditional Knowledge Digital Library (TKDL) in 2001. This process creates new modes of authority-making over yoga (Fish 2014; Sidhu 2017). Through what Anjali Vats has called ‘dewesternizing restructuring’, the TKDL aims to decolonise yoga by challenging Eurocentric intellectual property classifications and protecting ideals of collective ownership against privatisation (Vats 2016). Economically, India’s Ministry of Tourism has singled out yoga as a promising source of revenue within the category of wellness tourism (Ministry of Tourism, Government of India, n.d.). India has thus promoted the monetising of yoga through lifestyle industries. The religious entrepreneur Baba Ramdev, for instance, has encouraged Indians to become yogis and then seamlessly created lifestyle products for them to buy. These practices have aimed to reclaim yoga for Indian legal and economic benefit.

Ironically, this legal and economic decolonisation strategy – one that resonates to some degree with Gandhi’s *swadeshi* (self-sufficiency) movement and Nehru’s import substitution policies – has also gone hand in hand with a potentially recolonising Indian embrace of western stereotypes about India. While the idea of an exotic spiritual East has been widely bemoaned for decades, Indian government agencies appear to have embraced this stereotype in the hopes of monetising it. In this sense, they draw upon strategies deployed by twentieth-century Indian religious figures who strategically traded on orientalist perceptions of their mystical power (Mukherjee 2017). The long-running twenty-first-century Incredible India campaign has featured yoga in idealised spiritual terms. Taking control of this longstanding western fantasy, India’s nation-branding self-orientalises as a marketing strategy.

The second recolonising impulse can be found within the strong and growing link between yoga and Hindutva. Entrepreneurs such as Ramdev are often understood to promote Hindu-centric ideologies through personal self-care (Chakraborty 2007), while social service organisations such as the Vivekananda Kendra enmesh yoga within Hindu nationalist ideals (Pandya 2014). These projects sometimes seek to evacuate India of minorities, to justify caste hierarchies and discrimination based on work and descent and to create a model for aspirational world power. In these projects, yoga can become a tool to assert dominance over specific parts of India’s citizenry. The ascendance of Yogi Adityanath as chief minister of Uttar Pradesh signals such a symbolic utility for yoga. Leader of the Gorakhnath Math, Adityanath is notorious for inflammatory comments that allow the ruling party to benefit from Hindutva appeals while protecting national leaders from the stigma of extremism (Kaul 2017). These trends place yoga centrally within concerns that India, celebrating seventy years of democracy, has become increasingly majoritarian and resistant to minority rights (Jaffrelot 2017).

Yoga also potentially gives Hindu nationalist voices a platform within Indian diasporic outreach. In recent years, the Indian state has developed a ‘yoga diplomacy’ that merges Hindutva-inspired ideals with Nehruvian cultural nationalism (Gautam and Droogan 2018: 19). Organisations such as Sri Sri Ravi Shankar’s Art of Living Foundation and the Hindu Students Council in the United States have also pushed such agendas (Sood 2018: 14). In these contexts, yoga can become a vehicle for social groups to promote Hindutva globally as part of consciousness-raising for ethnic minority groups. It can also promote hierarchical and idealised narratives about Hinduism that often rely on the erasure of minority groups (especially Muslim ones) in the post-9/11 war on terror (Chandra 2015). Yoga thus plays a role as a potential and sometimes unwitting conduit for a globalising Hindutva.

The third potential form of recolonisation happening in India reflects the trend that many urban middle-class practitioners take up yoga as a western-legible form of modernity. The external validation that yoga has received around the world has increased its cache domestically. Indeed, this external popularity is at the heart of major government initiatives to capitalise on yoga: the state fears that the material benefits of yoga will be captured by other countries. International validation has made yoga more attractive for some Indian practitioners, while for others, the global popularity of the practice has inspired critical desires to reclaim and reassert an alternative Indian set of traditions (Askegaard and Eckhardt 2012).

While India's intensified interest in yoga in the twenty-first century has brought important decolonising impulses, the nationalist and religious agendas that have woven their way into the promotion of the practice also invite us to consider how diverse forms of yoga remediate influential articulations of hierarchy and control. As Indian governments, teachers and practitioners engage with the practice as a diverse and globalised one, these efforts have the potential to associate the transformative promise of yoga with selective agendas that rely on old and emerging social division. Decolonising yoga, thus, is no simple matter. What looks like 'decolonising' from one point of view may seem, from another angle, like a new imperial configuration.

Conclusion: towards yoga as critique

For scholars working from postcolonial perspectives, one of the most promising capacities of yoga is its potential to offer not simply an object of knowledge, but a knowledge modality useful for decolonial aspirations. If we conceptualise yoga in hopeful terms as a practical philosophy of transformation that promotes an expanded apprehension of reality, one of the most exciting possibilities is that yoga can give us the tools for better constructive critique. Postcolonial studies is well known for its ability to expose injury and injustice. It is less well known for its ability to articulate a viable way forward.

Yoga alone is unlikely to decolonise habits of thought and action. But, enmeshed with analysis and activism, it offers the possibility for embodied critique. One important twenty-first-century trend links yogic practice to demands for progressive collective action (Training Leaders Worldwide in Social Change, n.d.). While many 'off the mat' actions perpetuate missionary imperialism, it may still be possible for yoga to promote conscious reflection on the larger political orders that shape the world. Farah Godrej suggests that yogic methods can 'encourage attitudes and behaviors that directly counteract neoliberal subjectivity: cultivating a truthful inward gaze that reflects on and problematises the construction of one's own needs, desires, and self-image' (Godrej 2017: 788). To understand how this critical project might take shape, we as scholars need to examine more closely how practices of yoga interweave themselves with analytical and activist frameworks.

Yoga as an alternative form of knowing shapes important ongoing experiments in growing university fields of contemplative studies, where critical first-person pedagogies reanimate yoga's histories of self-experimentation for contemporary knowledge work. Such projects aim to decolonise the traditional Eurocentric scholarly forms of knowing at the heart of the modern university. Yet the price of admission for such decolonising work can be the severing of such contemplative practices from religious and devotional frameworks, so that secularity within a neoliberal paradigm becomes the new master narrative and condition of possibility that shapes yoga's legitimacy. As we as scholars work to cultivate yoga as a critical source of illumination in our writing and our teaching, we do so through intimacy with our own hegemonic forms.

I suggest it is through – not beyond – such uncomfortable intimacies that yoga offers us valuable ways of perceiving the world. Practicing yoga in critically self-reflective ways, in dialogue

with analytical and activist voices, can invite us to perceive the invisible layers of power that configure individual subjects and broader social landscapes. Such inquiry can potentially expose, if not escape, the diverse normalised hierarchies that have long shaped the conditions under which yoga transforms lives. Though decolonial projects may never be complete, full or perfected, there is value in their practice.

Notes

- 1 The RSS is a large Indian volunteer organisation associated with the promotion of Hindutva, or 'Hinduness', and it is often seen as aligned with the political goals of Hindu fundamentalism.
- 2 This brief sketch is of course incomplete and does not address key movements, such as the substantial migration of Indians to Gulf states. A welcome direction for future scholarship would investigate further the cultural politics of yoga in the Middle East.

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3

MEDITATION IN CONTEMPORARY CONTEXTS

Current discussions

Ville Husgafvel

Introduction

Since the counter-culture of the 1960s, the practice of meditation has spread from more marginal spiritual and religious contexts into the western (and increasingly global) cultural mainstream. This is most visible in the introduction of mindfulness-based programmes (MBPs), such as mindfulness-based stress reduction (MBSR) and mindfulness-based cognitive therapy (MBCT), as institutionalised approaches in public and corporate settings (Mindful Nation UK 2015; Wilson 2014).¹ The widespread application of Buddhist-derived mindfulness practices in healthcare, education and the corporate world is supported by a cumulative body of scientific research on their psychological and physiological benefits and the secular reframing of the aims, principles and premises of meditation practice. In recent years, academic research and public interest have created a positive feedback loop, providing increasing funding for mindfulness-related research and, in turn, scientific legitimisation for the use of practical mindfulness applications. Reflecting this surge in both academic and general attention, the number of mindfulness-related journal publications has grown from one per year in 1982 to ten in 2000, up to six hundred and ninety-two in 2017 (AMRA Resources and Services 2018). The vast majority of these studies come from the fields of behavioural, cognitive and medical sciences, but lately, research within the humanities and social sciences has increased significantly as well. In addition to standardised mindfulness-based programmes, other Buddhist or Buddhist-derived meditation styles are also attracting large numbers of contemporary practitioners, both within and beyond explicitly religious contexts. Globally, the most popular forms include Tibetan tantric approaches, various forms of Zen meditation and Theravāda-based *vipassanā* practices (taught, for example, by the Insight Meditation Society or the lineage of S. N. Goenka (1924–2013), as well as in more traditional Buddhist contexts).

The first worldwide wave of meditation practice was much indebted to Maharishi Mahesh Yogi's Transcendental Meditation (TM) movement, which included the members of the Beatles as its celebrity evangelists. While TM is still active today, other contemplative practices with Vedic-Brahmanic roots have occupied the global mainstream more recently. In particular, the different forms of modern yoga represent another major driving force in the popularisation of meditation, even if the explicit emphasis on meditative aspects varies greatly between styles (De Michelis 2004). In fact, in both historical and contemporary contexts, drawing too rigid

a boundary between ‘yoga’ and ‘meditation’ is problematic. Historically, the early roots of yoga and meditation go back to a shared pool of practices, concepts and soteriological structures employed by *śramaṇa* (i.e. Buddhist, Jain, Ājīvika) renunciates (Bronkhorst 2007; Samuel 2008). Instead of distinct ‘origins’ and clear ‘lineages’, the early Brahmanic, Buddhist and Jain histories of yoga and meditation are completely intertwined and cross-pollinated (Maas 2018; O’Brien-Kop 2017; Samuel 2008; Wujastyk 2018). In contemporary contexts, the concepts of ‘yoga’ and ‘meditation’ may sometimes be equally overlapping, even if in popular imaginaries ‘yoga’ is more associated with practices involving physical postures and ‘meditation’ with mental exercises conducted in a paradigmatic cross-legged sitting position (De Michelis 2004: 8). This overlap is evident in the inclusion of yoga postures in the ‘mindfulness meditation’ techniques of well-known MBPs, such as the MBSR programme (Kabat-Zinn 2005 [1990]: 94–113), or the application of various sitting and lying-down meditation techniques in modern yoga classes (De Michelis 2004: 251–260). Moreover, it requires just a slight shift in orientation to frame some Buddhist-derived sitting meditation techniques as ‘postural’ practices (see, e.g. Suzuki 1973 [1970]: 25–28) or postural yoga *āsanas* as dynamic forms of ‘meditation’ (see, e.g. De Michelis 2004: 238–239). Thus, depending on the framing, historical context, and preferred definitions, ‘yoga’ and ‘meditation’ may represent two distinct conceptual categories; ‘yoga’ may be a subcategory of ‘meditation practice’, ‘meditation’ a subcategory of ‘yoga practice’, or the terms can even be used interchangeably.²

Besides the formal contexts of modern mindfulness and yoga, meditation practices are often regarded as one signature element in the open-ended cultural formation known as ‘New Age’ or ‘holistic spirituality’ (Gilhus and Sutcliffe 2014; Hanegraaff 1996; Heelas and Woodhead 2005). This refers to various ways of life, social networks and cultural products that combine ideas and practices from a wide range of religious, spiritual and philosophical traditions into eclectic combinations of both therapeutic and soteriological significance. While highly visible in the current cultural landscape, the phenomenon is analytically elusive; again, clear definitions and categorisations are difficult. Despite maintaining a certain level of ambivalence – or even distance – in regard to more institutionalised forms of meditation, contemporary ‘holistic spirituality’ represents one popular cultural milieu for various contemplative practices. However, meditation practice itself should not be regarded as categorically ‘spiritual’ or associated with ‘New Age’, as done in some characterisations that lump together practices like ‘(spiritual) yoga, reiki, meditation, tai chi, aromatherapy, much paganism, rebirthing, reflexology, much wicca and many more’ (Heelas and Woodhead 2005: 7). Many scholars and contemporary practitioners of meditation, such as cognitive therapists working in the UK National Health Services (NHS) and using MBCT in their daily work, are likely to find these associations foreign and problematic.

Alongside characteristically contemporary developments, practices that could be referred to as ‘meditation’ continue to be important elements in many traditional religious and indigenous contexts; various forms of concentration, awareness, recitation, or visualisation practices are found in practically all religions and cultures from the Catholic Church to Amazonian tribal lifeways. This has led some scholars and scientists to make universalist claims about ‘meditation’ as ‘a worldwide practice found in every major religion and in most cultures’ (Walsh and Shapiro 2006: 229). However, others are highly cautious about whether collecting a wide range of practices from various geographical areas, cultural milieus and historical eras under the conceptual category of ‘meditation’ serves any analytical purposes or is just a remnant of outdated ‘intellectual trends’. As Lutz, Dunne and Davidson (2007: 500) argue,

[I]n a typical discussion of this kind [...] practices as diverse as the ritual dances of some African tribes, the spiritual exercises of the desert fathers, and the tantric

practices of a Tibetan adept are all forms of meditation. Historically, this attempt to categorize diverse practices under the same rubric reflects some intellectual trends in the early 20th century, most especially “perennialism,” that argue unequivocally for a certain genre of mystical experience as the essence of religion (Proudfoot, 1985; Sharf, 1998). ... [T]he generic use of meditation as applying to such a wide range of diverse practices inevitably trivializes the practices themselves. For example, the unique techniques and context of Sufi *zikr* must be ignored if they are to be considered the same as the Taoist practice of T’ai Chi. In short, to make *zikr* and T’ai Chi describable with the same term, one must ignore a good deal of what makes them radically different from each other. This would be akin to the use of the word “sport” to refer to all sports as if they were essentially the same.

(citations in original)

Whatever position one takes on these semantic and conceptual issues, it is worth keeping in mind that labelling something as ‘meditation’ is often more an argument in need of justification than a natural matter of fact just waiting to be ‘discovered’.

In the interest of space and scope, this chapter focuses on Buddhist-derived practices and especially the study of contemporary mindfulness, which dominates recent academic discussions on meditation. Besides the popular appeal of mindfulness training, there is much academic focus on Buddhist styles of meditation in the cognitive neurosciences, and the modernist narrative of Buddhism as a sort of ‘inner science of happiness’ seems to resonate well with contemporary cultural sensibilities (Lopez 2014; Lutz, Dunne and Davidson 2007; McMahan 2008; McMahan and Braun 2017). I have further narrowed my scope to a handful of themes, including challenges of definition, historical and comparative approaches, research positions and critical discourses. Through these, I hope to provide some insights into the current contributions and challenges of the humanistic and social scientific study of meditation.

Challenges of definition

Despite being widely used in both popular and academic discourses, there is no universally agreed-upon definition for ‘meditation’ as a specific category of human activity, and the term has a wide variety of context-dependent meanings and usages. The same applies for ‘mindfulness’ and much meditation-related terminology, which is usually rooted in the technical language of specific religious-philosophical traditions. When analysed in their ‘native’ contexts, the meaning of these terms may be defined in rich detail and precision, whether one is discussing the Greek term *melété* (Latin: *meditatio*) in early Christian asceticism and Stoic philosophy (Rönnegård 2013) or the Pāli *sati* (Sanskrit: *smṛti*, English: *mindfulness*) in certain Buddhist discourses (Dreyfus 2011; Gethin 2011 and 2015). However, problems arise when tradition-specific technical terms are used as signifiers for abstract conceptual constructions and universal categories of human experience.

In order to understand contemporary conceptualisations of ‘meditation’, it is useful to discern at least four basic stages in its conceptual history: (1) early Greek philosophy (Platonic, Stoic) and Christian asceticism; (2) medieval, premodern philosophy and Christian spirituality; (3) the comparative and historical study of ‘world religions’ starting in the colonial era (contributing to present-day usages in popular culture and cultural studies); and (4) contemporary medical, behavioural and cognitive sciences. In the first, ‘meditation’ usually refers to recitation, reflection and visualisation practices based on Biblical passages or other philosophical texts (Rönnegård 2013). In the second, these early usages are formalised in the sophisticated

technical terminology of Christian theology. Here, ‘meditation’ is often seen as a preparatory practice for ‘contemplation’, which represents a higher, non-discursive form of devotion, prayer and insight (Baier 2009). In the third, many technical distinctions between ‘meditation’ and ‘contemplation’ are left aside, so that both terms are adapted for comparative analyses and taxonomies, serving as denominators for a variety of religious-philosophical practices, especially those related to newly ‘discovered’ Buddhist, Vedic-Brahmanic and Daoist traditions (see, e.g. Burnouf 1844; Müller 1859). This same time period, the late nineteenth century, also witnessed new approaches in western esotericism, such as the influential Theosophical Society, which had distinct ways of characterising ‘meditation’, building both on indigenous western traditions and influences from Asian religions and philosophies (Baier 2012). In the fourth, the focus is shifted from religions and philosophies to the scientific study of universal neurological, physiological and psychological processes related to meditative techniques and resultant states (see, e.g. Lutz, Dunne and Davidson 2007). While each of these discourses builds their specific definitions and usages on the basis of previous ones, there are significant divergences and gaps between them.

In contemporary discussions, conceptualisations of ‘meditation’ in Buddhist and cultural studies often differ significantly from the perspectives of medical, behavioural and cognitive sciences, where the focus is mostly on the cognitive, emotional and physiological processes involved. This is evident, for example, in the early work of Daniel Goleman, in which he connects Buddhist *abhidhamma* (Sanskrit: *abhidharma*) philosophy with western psychotherapy and defines meditation as ‘the self-regulation and retraining of attentional habits’ (Goleman 1976: 44). More recently, Roger Walsh and Shauna Shapiro (2006: 228–229) have continued the dialogue between western psychology and meditative disciplines, suggesting that,

The term *meditation* refers to a family of self-regulation practices that focus on training attention and awareness in order to bring mental processes under greater voluntary control and thereby foster general mental well-being and development and/or specific capacities such as calm, clarity, and concentration.

(italics in original)

Similar reasoning can be found in one of the most cited scientific articles on the definition and typology of meditation by Antoine Lutz et al. (2008: 163):

Meditation can be conceptualized as a family of complex emotional and attentional regulatory training regimes developed for various ends, including the cultivation of well-being and emotional balance.

Sometimes further methodical details are listed, as exemplified in the following influential attempt at standardisation by Roberto Cardoso et al. (2004: 59):

To be characterized as meditation, the procedure must contain the following operational parameters: Utilizes a (1) specific technique (clearly defined), involving (2) muscle relaxation somewhere during the process and (3) “logic relaxation”: a necessarily (4) self-induced state, using a (5) self-focus skill (coined “anchor”).

In all these characterisations, ‘meditation’ is defined and described in highly technical and individualistic ways with little explicit attention to its cultural and social aspects. This, of course, fits the overall objective of finding universal patterns in human physiology and behaviour

which are not dependent on contextual factors.³ However, when compared to emblematic conceptualisations in Buddhist and cultural studies, the differences are striking.

Buddhist meditation – as a systematic methodology for uncovering and transforming the basis of our understanding of the world – can be seen as an essentially hermeneutical enterprise ... The various Buddhist meditation techniques are deeply embedded in a larger world view. Buddhist meditation puts into practice the Buddhist understanding of the world.

(Gregory 1986: 5–6)

Contemplative practices are modes of self-cultivation that strive to produce certain experiences and cultivate certain ways of being in a world – a world that contains particular normative understandings of a good life, a holy life, a successful life, as well as conceptions of the person, the mind and its features, the potential for human development and cultivation, and various experiences that meditators will have at different stages on the path.

(McMahan 2017: 38)

Here, meditation practice is not seen as an isolated individual enterprise; rather, it is inseparably embedded in history, culture and various socially constructed frames that give purpose and direction for the practice (see also Eifring 2015). Thus, while the intentional self-regulation of attention, awareness and other cognitive-emotional processes represent important technical features of meditation, this is only half of the picture. Without analysing the role of contextual factors, many aspects of meditation remain obscure. This highlights the need for interdisciplinary collaborations, as emphasised by David McMahan, among others:

The level of analysis that attends only to universal physiological structure and function [...] cannot adequately account for how these practices work in practitioners' lives. If we are to take seriously the first-person perspective of contemplatives, we must understand how they conceive of the meaning, purpose, and significance of their practices in their doctrinal, social, cultural, and cosmic contexts. To understand contemplative practices in a comprehensive way, therefore, scientific study of meditation must work hand in hand with philosophers, anthropologists, sociologists, and scholars of religion who can help articulate these contexts.

(McMahan 2017: 43–44)

Even if the focus is purely on measurable and repeatable data in laboratory settings, scholars can help scientists to develop a more nuanced understanding of different meditative approaches in order to better define their research objects and control the many variables involved (see, e.g. Lutz, Dunne and Davidson 2007; Lutz et al. 2008). It is not difficult to understand the problems of making detailed conclusions on the physiological or psychological effects of 'sports' in general, instead of focusing specifically on long-distance running versus bowling, snowboarding and so forth. However, it might still surprise some that the same goes for 'meditation'; there are profound differences, for example, between 'focused attention', 'open-monitoring', or 'compassion' practices (see Hofmann, Grossman and Hinton 2011; Lutz et al. 2008; Pace et al. 2009). Even if these differences are not always outwardly perceptible, they are no less significant, and they need to be understood properly in any meditation-related scientific research.

Historical and comparative approaches

Mapping the history of specific meditative approaches and analysing their characteristic features represent established approaches within cultural studies. Early on, these descriptions appeared as part of broad introductory books on Buddhism and other Asian religions. Later, they became a topic in their own right, first through general works like Edward Conze's *Buddhist Meditation* (1956), and then gradually with more specific areas of focus in works such as *Mahāyāna Buddhist Meditation: Theory and Practice* (Kiyota and Jones 1991 [1978]), *Theravāda Meditation: The Buddhist Transformation of Yoga* (King 2015 [1980]), and *Traditions of Meditation in Chinese Buddhism* (Gregory 1986). This process of increasing the 'resolution' has continued steadily, and today there is a wealth of studies concentrating on particular techniques, lineages or historical and cultural contexts. Examples abound, such as Sam van Schaik's *Approaching the Great Perfection: Simultaneous and Gradual Methods of Dzogchen Practice in the Longchen Nyintig* (2004) or Eric Braun's *The Birth of Insight: Meditation, Modern Buddhism, and the Burmese Monk Ledi Sayadaw* (2013).

Outside of discussions in Buddhist studies, Braun's work is frequently cited in the study of contemporary meditation and mindfulness, as influences from Burmese Theravāda Buddhism are nowadays widespread. Many characteristic practices in the Insight Meditation Society, the *vipassanā* tradition of S. N. Goenka or MBSR and related MBPs can be traced back to the practice lineages of Ledi Sayādaw (1846–1923) and his student U Ba Khin (1899–1971) or Mingun Jetawun Sayādaw (1868–1955) and his student Mahasi Sayadaw (1904–1982) (Fronsdal 1998; Husgafvel 2016; Stuart 2018). Burma is also the birthplace of the first large-scale Buddhist lay meditation movement, closely following (and related) to the colonial conquest of Burma in the late-nineteenth century (Braun 2013; Houtman 1990; Jordt 2007; Stuart 2018). However, there is more to the Buddhist origins of current mindfulness-based programmes than these influential lineages and developments.

While scholars are in broad consensus on the overall Buddhist roots of contemporary mindfulness approaches, arguments diverge significantly in more detailed discussions. A common narrative presents modernised Theravāda-based *vipassanā* traditions, such as the aforementioned Burmese lineages and the Thai Forest tradition of Ajahn Chah (1918–1992) (mediated via Insight Meditation Society teachers), as principal Buddhist influences for the pioneering MBSR programme and related MBPs (see, e.g. Bodhi 2016; Braun 2013; Fronsdal 1998; Gethin 2011; R. King 2016; Monteiro, Musten and Compson 2015; Olendzki 2014; Purser and Milillo 2015; Samuel 2016; Sun 2014). However, a number of studies question this approach as one-sided and simplistic. The impact of Theravāda-based *vipassanā* practices should be acknowledged, but attention must also be drawn to direct and formative influences from 'non-dual' Mahāyāna approaches, such as East Asian Chan (Zen/Thiền/Sōn) schools and Tibetan Dzogchen practice, in both the practical methods and theoretical basis of the pioneering MBSR programme (Braun 2017; Dunne 2011; Husgafvel 2016 and 2018; Watt 2017).

Besides filling an important gap in the history and genealogy of contemporary mindfulness approaches, the recognition of signature Mahāyāna influences has significant implications for comparative approaches, which aim at discerning shared elements between current forms of mindfulness training and more traditional Buddhist practices. For example, a 'world-affirming' orientation or the emphasis on developing 'non-judgemental' awareness, both being characteristic of MBSR practice, are commonly pointed to as disparities in relation to 'classical' or 'traditional' Buddhist practices. However, when one's examination of Buddhist sources is extended beyond the Theravāda tradition and Pāli texts, both of these aspects can be found in established Mahāyāna Buddhist commentaries and practice lineages (Husgafvel 2016 and 2018).

Different understandings about which Buddhist traditions are relevant and a lack of sensitivity towards their differences may partially explain why scholarly discussions have yet to reach consensus on the degree of continuity between Buddhist teachings and contemporary mindfulness

practices. Depending on one's viewpoint, MBSR and other MBPs may represent 'the original teachings of the Buddha' in a secular form (Cullen 2011: 189–192), a characteristically American form of socially-engaged Buddhism 'streamlined for a secular clientele' (Seager 1999: 214; see also Wilson 2014), 'stealth Buddhism' with possible covert religious agendas (Brown 2016: 84), or pragmatic mindfulness applications with early Buddhist antecedents (Anālayo 2018 and 2019). However, another common narrative depicts MBSR and related contemporary mindfulness programmes as privatised, de-ethicised therapeutic techniques, which are a far cry from any authentic forms of Buddhist practice (Plank 2011; Purser and Loy 2013; Purser and Milillo 2015; Shonin, Van Gordon and Griffiths 2013).

Similarly, there are difficulties in fitting contemporary MBPs into dominant post-Enlightenment conceptual matrices, which dichotomize 'religion' and 'secular' into clearly distinct, binary categories. While scientific research literature usually presents mindfulness practices as axiomatically secular (Baer 2015; Didonna 2009; Lutz et al. 2008; see also Sun 2014), some scholars argue that they exhibit characteristically religious content (Brown 2016). Others see them as transcending the binary model altogether by sacralising the secular (Arat 2017), enchanting the natural world (Braun 2017), or forming cultural hybrids which are open for both religious and secular interpretations (Frisk 2012).

This ambivalence in scholarly categorisations is mirrored in (and reflects) broader societal discussions. Even if the implementation of mindfulness training in public contexts is generally widely accepted, in some instances this has been contested as a violation of religious freedom and the constitutional separation between church and state. Recently, these claims were made against the Dennis-Yarmouth Regional School District in Cape Cod, Massachusetts, due to the inclusion in public school curricula of an educational mindfulness-based programme called 'Calmer Choice'. A letter written by the lawyer Dean Broyles on behalf of the National Center for Law & Policy (NCLP) and 'concerned parents' states:

[T]here is a concern that mindfulness meditation involves well-established Buddhist religious beliefs and practices that may undermine rights of conscience and religious freedom because the curriculum may conflict with worldviews or religious beliefs adopted by students and inculcated by parents at home.

(Broyles 2016)

These claims repeat arguments of an earlier civil court case on the implementation of a yoga programme based on the Ashtanga Vinyasa Yoga tradition of Pattabhi Jois (1915–2009) in the Encinitas School District (Mayer 2013a; Newcombe 2018) in California. The only major difference was that the more recent perceived danger to religious neutrality in school curricula came from 'stealth Buddhism' instead of 'stealth Hinduism', as framed by Broyles (2017 and 2016). These views follow the arguments of the religious studies scholar Candy Gunther Brown,⁴ whom the lawyer uses as his expert witness. Even if the two cases reflect concerns of particular political and religious minorities marked by 'contemporary neo-conservative politics and conservative Christian faith' (Newcombe 2018: 558; see also NCLP 2018), and both school programmes continue with wide support from local communities, these debates are good reminders that academic argumentation is not isolated from the wider society but completely embedded in it – with all the practical, political and ethical implications that follow.

Research positions

The unique position of each scholar towards his or her objects of study represents another, different example of the inevitable embeddedness of academic research. Besides societal

institutions, structures and debates, each argument and study reflects the personal motivations, backgrounds, beliefs and prior understandings of the researcher. Current mindfulness research provides a relevant context for understanding this, as personal religious or ideological backgrounds may sometimes play a considerable role, even if the topic is quite rarely explicitly discussed. (See Rahmani, Chapter 18 in this volume.)

Anyone studying the Buddhist history, ethical dimensions, commercial aspects or religious-secular nature of contemporary mindfulness-based programmes will soon discern some basic standpoints, which frame to different degrees the content and tone of scholarly argumentation. These may include, for example, personal and professional engagement in MBPs, commitment to Buddhist practice, adherence to conservative Christian values and beliefs, or emancipatory motivations based on anti-capitalist, feminist and postcolonial critiques. Thus, a critical reader needs to remain alert to ideological, religious, political or commercial interests and presuppositions potentially at play in various analyses and depictions. For example, a reader could question if and how my scholar-practitioner position as both an academic researcher in the study of religion and a trained MBSR teacher might affect the perspectives or sources I choose and arguments I make in this chapter.

Naturally, personal entanglement in religious practices, yoga and meditation – or the politics and businesses surrounding them – is not in itself a reason to question the integrity or quality of any particular study. Quite the contrary; in many cases the advantages of personal experience and engagement in the field are obvious, as many nuances in both ethnographic and historical source materials can go unnoticed without insight from lived experience. Moreover, despite positivist idealisations of ‘objective and value-free’ research, it is practically impossible to escape ‘subjectivity’ in any form of qualitative research (or even the natural sciences, at least when communicated through language). While unique personal positions towards research objects affect how they are perceived and framed, and the language which one uses to form and communicate arguments is only partially shared and understood by others, this does not diminish the value of the scholarly enterprise. It merely puts emphasis on the intersubjective nature of academic knowledge production. Only time and peer discussion (or a lack of it) will determine the value and authenticity of any particular work.

This being said, there are academic conventions that support the transparency of one’s position and the reliability of findings from the beginning. When the subjective situatedness or embeddedness of each scholar and ‘knowledge product’ is recognised, it is necessary to make one’s research position and agency explicit and visible. In this way, scholars can provide the reader with the possibility to better contextualise and evaluate the argument being made. These methodological standpoints, based on reflexivity and applied early on in ethnography and anthropology, are already ‘a major strategy for quality control’ in many areas of qualitative research (Berger 2015: 219). Through the growing trend towards ethnographic approaches in the study of MBPs (Cook 2016; Crane et al. 2015; Drage 2018; Rosch 2015; Wheater 2017), together with critical interdisciplinary discussions on methodology, explicit self-reflection by scholars on their personal research position is hopefully becoming standard procedure also in the study of contemporary mindfulness.

Critical discourses

While there is a great deal of enthusiasm about the possible positive effects of meditation and mindfulness practices for both individuals and society at large, more and more critical voices are being heard. In scientific critiques of mindfulness and meditation studies, the focus has been on possible positive reporting bias, apparent methodological flaws and a lack of attention towards

difficult meditation-related experiences (see, e.g. Coronado-Montoya et al. 2016; Goyal et al. 2014; Lindahl et al. 2017). These issues have contributed to overenthusiastic and exaggerated views on the benefits of meditation, even if empirical evidence in many cases is only promising and in need of further validation. In cultural studies, critical discourses tend to not target research and reporting standards per se, but rather the contemporary approaches and contexts of meditation themselves. Here, the individualisation, secularisation, decontextualisation, commodification, corporatisation and even militarisation of traditional Buddhist meditation practices are problematised and interrogated from various perspectives, including critical theory, postcolonial and feminist studies and also traditional Buddhist positions (see, e.g. Purser, Forbes and Burke 2016). According to these critics, ‘denatured’ contemporary forms of mindfulness practice may in the service of neoliberal ideologies, corporate profit-making and military objectives become ‘tools of oppression’ instead of beneficial and liberative practices. While recent ‘McMindfulness’ debates (Hyland 2015; Purser and Loy 2013; Shonin and Kabat-Zinn 2015) have perhaps gained the most visibility in popular discussions, these arguments can be traced to Slavoj Žižek’s much earlier critical (and polemical) takes on ‘Western Buddhism’ (see also Cook 2016).

One is almost tempted to resuscitate here the old infamous Marxist cliché of religion as the “opium of the people,” as the imaginary supplement of the terrestrial misery: the “Western Buddhist” meditative stance is arguably the most efficient way, for us, to fully participate in the capitalist dynamic while retaining the appearance of mental sanity. If Max Weber were alive today, he would definitely write a second, supplementary, volume to his *Protestant Ethic*, entitled *The Taoist Ethic and the Spirit of Global Capitalism*.

(Žižek 2006 [2001]: 13)

Besides Žižek’s writings, Michel Foucault’s analytical and conceptual tools are widely used in theorising contemporary contemplative practices from critical and philosophical perspectives. Foucauldian ideas on ‘governmentality’, ‘freedom as practice’, ‘care of self’, and ‘technologies of the self’ open possibilities for perceiving traditional and contemporary forms of meditation as both possibly oppressive techniques of social-political governing and disruptive, emancipatory practices of individual and social liberation, depending on the context and perspective (see, e.g. Ng 2016).

Finally, it may be added that more discussion on methodological issues is also needed in the cultural and historical study of meditation and mindfulness. As has been commonly recognised, the early orientalist works focusing on Buddhism and other Asian religions were dominated by philological approaches, which reflected particular Protestant Christian values and orientations in their focus on ‘holy scriptures’ as the prime location of religious ‘truths’ (see King 1999; Samuel 2008: 15–22). In the early study of Buddhism in the west, orientalist presuppositions contributed to problematic value-laden constructions of ‘true Buddhism’, which prioritised normative canonical texts at the expense of contemporary Buddhist practices (and archaeological evidence) and the Pāli Canon of the Theravāda School at the expense of other Buddhist traditions (King 1999: 143–160; Samuel 2008: 16–17; Schopen 1997: 1–22; Sharf 1995). Even if these dispositions no longer dominate the mainstream study of Buddhism, ‘the idea of a “real” Buddhism that can be found in the Pāli Canon rather than the practice of historical and contemporary Buddhists remains alive and well’ (Samuel 2008: 17).

The persistence of orientalist ideas in academic research is evident in the study of contemporary mindfulness. Essentialist presentations of ‘classical’ or ‘traditional’ Buddhism, Buddhist meditation and Buddhist mindfulness are still commonly based on canonical Pāli texts and

Theravāda commentaries (Husgafvel 2016). Sometimes, these normative ahistorical constructs of ‘true mindfulness’ are further contrasted with anecdotal ethnographic examples from ‘corrupted’ contemporary mindfulness approaches (see, e.g. Purser 2015: 32) in ways which repeat classic orientalist patterns (see King 1999: 146). While possibly serving some practical or argumentative purposes, these dispositions omit: the complex interplay between Buddhist textual descriptions and lived practices of meditation, the various versions and editions (i.e. Pāli, Sanskrit, Chinese) of particular Buddhist texts, the different commentarial and practical traditions related to meditation and mindfulness practice (*P. satipaṭṭhāna*, *S. smṛtyupasthāna*) within Tibetan and East Asian Mahāyāna Buddhism and the problems of asymmetrical data when the normative textual descriptions of one tradition (Theravāda Buddhism) are compared to prescriptive ethnographic descriptions of another (MBSR). Thus, the call for more rigorous methodological standards applies not only in the quantitative empirical sciences but also in the historical and comparative study of contemporary meditation and mindfulness, even if on very different grounds.

Conclusion

It seems appropriate to end this brief discussion on current debates in contemporary meditation studies by sketching possible future developments. Through questions of definition and classification, dialogue between scientific and cultural studies will continue to develop our understanding on the characteristic features of meditation practice in general and on the distinct features of specific contemplative approaches in particular. Attempts at defining ‘meditation’ as a universal conceptual category may be helpful in drawing the basic outlines of an emerging field of research, but in terms of actual studies the major contributions are likely to deal more with increasing an understanding of context-specific features and terminology than with abstract generalisations. It is precisely due to their contextual understanding of meditation practices and sensitiveness towards problems of essentialism and universalisation that scholars of Buddhism and other meditation-related fields are critically important for – and increasingly being called to collaborate with – cognitive neuroscience and psychological research projects.

While the use of conceptual categories is indispensable in making sense of the world in which we live, they are bound to particular cultural and historical frames, whether emic or etic, scientific or popular, western or Asian. Being aware of the history and limitations of particular semantic and conceptual frames is part of the expertise developed in cultural studies. Research on yoga and meditation does not comprise an exception, but rather the opposite. Both historical and contemporary forms of yoga and meditation occupy many different cultural spheres and spaces simultaneously; while some of these are clearly ‘secular’, ‘religious’, ‘Buddhist’, or ‘Brahmanic’ when compared to western prototypes or classifications of ‘world religions’,⁵ many others are ‘something in-between’ and challenge established systems of codification. For more theoretically oriented scholars, empirical data on contemplative practices provides both an impetus and a rich testing ground for much-needed, novel ways of conceptualising cultural phenomena. For everyone in the field – be they more or less entrenched in the use of ‘religion’, ‘secular’, ‘Buddhism’, ‘Hinduism’, ‘yoga’, ‘meditation’, or ‘mindfulness’ as analytical categories – adopting non-essentialist, discursive, instrumental and situational approaches towards these concepts will likely turn out to be useful or even inevitable (see Masuzawa 2005; Newcombe 2018: 570; Taira 2013; Wilson 2014: 9).

In historical and comparative studies, a more nuanced picture of both contemporary mindfulness approaches, Buddhist meditative traditions, and the many links between them is likely to emerge. Currently, many arguments and assumptions are made about ‘contemporary mindfulness’ or the ‘mindfulness movement’ with little sensitivity towards the wide variety of

programmes, interventions, applications, products, teachers, motivations and contexts that can be connected to the fuzzy concept of ‘mindfulness’. To put it bluntly, when the branding of mayonnaise, clinical cognitive therapy, techniques for increased sexual pleasure and a way of life guided by ethical and philosophical ideals are all gathered under the rubric of ‘mindfulness’ and treated as ‘a movement’ (see Wilson 2014), it seems highly questionable whether any shared agendas, identities or arguments can be found. As is the case with meditation and yoga traditions overall, a more clear understanding and sensitiveness to the heterogeneity and subtle differences between (and within) current mindfulness approaches will greatly benefit future discussions.

Finally, while research will continue to be conducted from various points of view, the shadows of positivist idealisations will hopefully no longer haunt scholars and lead them to downplay their subjectivity and agency in argumentation. In order for peer discussion to separate the ‘wheat from the chaff’, there must be genuine dialogue between scholars, academic disciplines and preferred schools of thought. At the moment, there are many separate ‘pillars’ or ‘bubbles’ of knowledge in the study of meditation, mindfulness and yoga, to the detriment of all. Naturally it takes effort to keep track of different discussions and courage to challenge all views (especially one’s own), but these are foundational goals if we hope to avoid reducing academic debates and knowledge into parallel monologues of ‘alternative truths’. By means of continuing curiosity, self-reflection and critical discussion beyond disciplinary boundaries and personal comfort zones, there is much to learn – for the benefit of academics, practitioners and society at large – about the diverse complex of practices which fall under the rubric of ‘meditation’ in contemporary contexts.

Notes

- 1 Standardised programmes include, for example, mindfulness-based stress reduction (MBSR), mindfulness-based cognitive therapy (MBCT), mindfulness-based mind-fitness training (MMFT), mindfulness-based eating awareness training (MB-EAT), mindfulness-based relapse prevention (MBRP), mindfulness-based childbirth and parenting (MBCP), and mindfulness-based elder care (MBEC).
- 2 In academia, these historical and contemporary premises question the conceptualisation of ‘yoga studies’ and ‘meditation studies’ as two clearly distinct fields of research, and also the earlier field-specific approaches of studying yoga in ‘Hindu’ (Vedic-Brahmanic) studies and meditation in Buddhist (also Jain, Daoist, etc.) studies. Thus, the name ‘yoga and meditation studies’ can be seen not so much as indicating a combination of two different research fields but as merely capturing different aspects of one shared field.
- 3 For a critique of ‘context-independent’ approaches in the study of meditation within the cognitive sciences, see Thompson 2017.
- 4 Candy Gunther Brown is an established scholar in religious studies, but her views on the religiosity of yoga and mindfulness appear to be influenced by her ideological and political positioning (see also Newcombe 2018). Brown has repeatedly worked as the main academic expert on behalf of the National Center for Law & Policy (NCLP), a non-profit legal group ‘closely associated with ideological positions of contemporary neo-conservative politics and conservative Christian faith’ (Newcombe 2018; NCLP 2018) in US court cases and legal concerns against the use of yoga and mindfulness practices in public schools. In the *Sedlock v. Baird* case on the use of yoga in the Encinitas School District, the court explicitly stated that ‘Dr. Brown is not objective and not creditable and Dr. Brown is biased’ (Mayer 2013a). Moreover, the judge considered Dr. Brown almost ‘to be on a mission against Ashtanga yoga’ (Mayer 2013b). For Brown’s responses and more discussion, see Deslippe 2017 and Brown 2013.
- 5 On the ‘invention of world religions’ see Masuzawa 2005.

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